

◀ COPPER COVERING

The sculptor Frédéric Bartholdi chose copper sheeting $\frac{3}{32}$ in (2.3mm) thick to cover the statue, as cast bronze sheets or stone cladding would have been too expensive and too heavy to transport.

Statue of Liberty

A gift from the people of France to the people of the United States that symbolizes freedom and enlightenment



Standing tall on Liberty Island in New York Harbor, the Statue of Liberty has welcomed immigrants and visitors to the US ever since it was dedicated on October 28, 1886. The 151-ft- (46-m-) tall copper statue is a figure of Libertas, the Roman goddess of liberty. Holding a torch in her right hand to enlighten the world and a tablet in her left hand inscribed with the Roman numerals for the date of the US Declaration of Independence from Great Britain—July 4, 1776—the statue stands proudly free, the broken chains of bondage at her feet.

French origins, American finance

The idea of the statue arose in France when law professor and politician Edouard René de Laboulaye remarked to the sculptor Frédéric Auguste Bartholdi

that any monument raised to commemorate American independence should be a joint project between the American and French people, given their revolutionary ties. Bartholdi completed the head and the torch-bearing arm before he had designed the rest of the statue. He exhibited the arm at the Centennial Exposition in Philadelphia in 1876, and later in New York. Fundraising proved a problem until Joseph Pulitzer, publisher of the *New York World*, appealed for funds, which then poured in from more than 120,000 contributors.

The statue itself was built in France by Gustave Eiffel, later famous for his eponymous tower in Paris (see pp.180–181), and shipped to the US. Its completion was marked by New York's first ticker-tape parade, its dedication presided over by President Grover Cleveland.



▷ HOLDING THE TORCH

Like the rest of the statue, the hand that holds the torch was made in Paris, then dismantled and shipped across the Atlantic in 200 crates. It was reassembled in what was then called Bedloe's Island, New York.

The torch alone is **16 ft (5 m)** tall and weighs **1 $\frac{3}{4}$ tons (1.6 tonnes)**

IRON FRAMEWORK

The statue was designed around an iron frame. A secondary framework was attached to the central pillar to enable the statue to move slightly in the winds of the harbor. Then, sections of outer copper skin were connected to it using metal straps known as saddles. The skin was insulated with asbestos impregnated with shellac to prevent corrosion between the copper skin and the iron supports.

